Federal Foreign Office

Visa for Germany

FAQ ?!

Visa for Germany

We hope you understand that we cannot respond individually to questions featured in this catalogue.

Please contact the Help Desk if you haven't found the answer to your question.

You are living abroad and you are in need of consular information? Please contact the German
mission which is competent for your place of residence.

- German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

Do I need a visa for Germany?

On the Federal Foreign Office webpage you can find out whether you need a visa for visits to Germany and the Schengen states of up to 90 days. Most non-EU-foreigners wanting to work or study in Germany or to stay longer than 90 days in Germany for other purposes, usually need a visa.

Exceptions are indicated in the relevant list of countries.

- Overview of visa requirements/exemptions for entry into the Federal Republic of Germany
- The Schengen Agreement
  - Visa regulations

I am a (non-German) EU citizen and want to visit Germany with my spouse (who is not an EU citizen). Does my spouse need a visa?

If you and/or your spouse live in a Schengen country, the situation is as follows:

As holder of a residence permit issued by a Schengen country, you need no visa for short-term stays in other Schengen countries - so you need no visa for Germany either. In any 180 days period you may stay for up to 90 days maximum in another Schengen country. Please check with the relevant authorities in your country of residence whether your spouse's residence permit entitles him or her to visa-free travel within the Schengen area.

If you or your spouse live in an EU country where the Schengen Agreement does not apply or not apply in full, the situation is as follows:

If the authorities of your country of residence have issued your spouse with a “residence card of a family member of a Union citizen” pursuant to Art. 10(1) of Directive 2004/38/EC, he or she needs no visa for travel within the EU.

If you and your spouse live outside the EU, your spouse will need an entry visa if he or she is from a country subject to a visa regime. In this case, however, a facilitated visa procedure applies.

If you have further questions, please visit the website of the relevant German mission or contact the mission directly.

The EU provides a guide to your rights as an EU citizen.

Are there special visa arrangements for EU citizens?

EU citizens do not need a visa to visit, live or work in Germany. They only have to register at the local German registration office (Einwohnermeldeamt).

Additional information is available at the European Job Mobility Portal.

- European Job Mobility Portal
  - Visa regulations

Do foreigners with a residence permit for one of the Schengen member states need a visa to visit Germany?

Please note that not all EU members fully apply the Schengen Agreement, but that some non-EU countries do apply it fully.

Non-EU citizens living in one of the countries that do apply the agreement fully (so-called Schengen States) with a valid residence permit do not need a visa for visits to Germany of up to 90 days in any period of 180 days when not taking up work.

Schengen states:

Austria, Belgium, Bulgaria, Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Italy, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Rumania, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden and

Switzerland. For non-EU citizens living in another European country regular visa regulations apply.

- Overview of visa requirements/exemptions for entry into the Federal Republic of Germany
  - Visa regulations

My visa was issued by a mission of another Schengen state. Can I use it to travel to Germany?

Yes. Holders of

- a Schengen visa (text on the visa reads “valid for Schengen states”),

- a residence permit of a member state or

- a national visa of a member state

can also travel to Germany for up to 90 days in any period of 180 days.

The Schengen visa should, however, have been issued by a mission of the country which is the main destination. The country of entry and departure is not the determining factor.

- What countries are Schengen states?
  - Visa regulations

I'm planning a trip by air and have to transit at a German airport. Do I need a visa?

The vast majority of foreign travellers benefit from the “transit privilege” - if during a stopover at a German airport, you do not leave the International Airport Area and if the destination is not in a Schengen country, you do not need a transit visa.

However, if for some reason you need to enter the Schengen area during your stopover (for example to change terminals or if the destination is in a Schengen country), you may require a visa; please plan for this. You should apply for a visa well before you travel!

Only five airports in Germany have an International Transit Area enabling you to transit without formally entering the Schengen area:

- Frankfurt/Main
- Munich
- Hamburg (4.30 a.m. - 11.30 p.m. only)

- Düsseldorf (6.00 a.m. - 9.00 p.m. only) and if the airline has arranged the transit beforehand with the authorities responsible for cross-border security (the Federal Police)
- Berlin-Brandenburg

Nationals of the following countries do not have the transit privilege and therefore require an airport transit visa (category A) for transit at a German airport:

- Afghanistan
- Bangladesh
- Cuba
- Democratic Republic of the Congo
- Eritrea
- Ethiopia
- Ghana
- Iran
- Iraq
- Jordan *
- Lebanon
- Mali
- Nigeria
- Pakistan
- Somalia
- South Sudan
- Sri Lanka
- Sudan
- Syria
- Turkey *

* certain exceptions apply to these countries

The following people **are exempt** from the need for an airport transit visa:

- holders of valid visas and national residence permits of EU and Schengen states
- holders of certain national residence permits of the following states: Andorra, Japan, Canada, San Marino, United States of America
- holders of valid visas from EEA countries (EU states, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, Switzerland) as well as visas issued by Japan, Canada and the United States of America
- family members of EU citizens entitled to freedom of movement (spouses, registered partners, children, grandchildren under the age of 21 years; parents and grandparents, provided they are maintained by the EU citizen)
    - Visa regulations

I don't need a visa for my trip to Germany, but are there other things I should bear in mind?

You can only enter Germany if you have valid identity papers. On the planned date of departure from Germany, your passport has to be valid at least for another three months and it has to be issued within the last 10 years.

In certain cases, documents have to be presented that prove the purpose and circumstances of the visit.

Similarly, proof may also have to be provided that you have sufficient funds to maintain yourself during your stay and to finance the return trip. The amount of funding depends on the type and length of stay. There are no fixed daily rates.

You are advised to take out health insurance before your trip which also covers return transport to your home country.

In cases of repeated entries and a longer duration foreigners who are not nationals of a European Union or European Economic Area state must bear in mind that visits to the Schengen area are restricted to 90 days in any period of 180 days.

For longer stays for example to study or take up employment, different regulations often apply.

- What is the procedure for applying for a work visa?
- What is the procedure for applying for a student visa?
    - Visa regulations

My visa was issued by a German mission abroad. Can I use it to travel to other countries in Europe?

Do I have to enter and leave via Germany or can I do so elsewhere?

Yes, you can. Holders of

- a Schengen visa (text on the visa reads “valid for Schengen states”)

- a residence permit of a member state or

- a national visa (D-visa)

can stay in the entire Schengen area for up to 90 days in any period of 180 days. The Schengen area consists of the following countries:

Germany, Austria, Belgium, Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Italy, Latvia, Liechtenstein, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden and Switzerland.

The Schengen visa has to be applied for at the foreign mission of the country which is the main destination. The country of entry and departure is not the determining factor. The entry into and departure from the Schengen area can thus occur at any border crossing.

- Visa regulations

I am a foreigner living in Germany and am planning a trip abroad. Do I need a valid passport and visa?

As a foreigner you are requested to hold a valid passport or document in lieu of a passport at any time. In general, the issuance and extension of foreign passports have to be applied for at the competent foreign missions in Germany, except for recognized asylum seekers, recognized refugees according to the Geneva Refugee Convention, stateless persons or those entitled to subsidiary protection. The mentioned groups are mostly issued a passport in lieu of a passport (Passersatzpapier) by the local Immigration Office (Ausländerbehörde) at the place of residence. There are three types of those documents:

- Travel document for refugees (“Blue Passport”)

- Travel document for stateless persons

- Travel document for foreigners

Holders of Blue Passports are in general allowed to travel to all the countries which have signed the Geneva Refugee Convention. Please note that for many of these countries, however, you may have to apply for a visa in advance. Information on visa provisions for non-German citizens wanting to travel to a third country can only be provided by the respective foreign mission of the country concerned. The addresses of the foreign missions in Germany are available here:

Foreign Missions in Germany

However, you are not allowed to travel to your country of origin - this would imply that you no longer need humanitarian protection; you risk losing your asylum in Germany if you travel to your home country.

Foreign nationals who are in possession of a valid German residence title (Aufenthaltstitel) may travel for a period of up to 90 days within 180 days to other Schengen-States, so do not need a visa.
This applies as well to holders of a German Visa of the category “D”.

In both cases, general entry requirements of Article 6 Section 1 letters a, c and e of the Regulation (EU) 2016/399 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 9 March 2016 on a Union Code on the rules governing the movement of persons across borders (Schengen Borders Code) are fulfilled and the person is not listed by the relevant Member State as not permitted.

In case of doubt please get in touch with the competent mission of the country in Germany.

- Who are Member States of the Schengen Agreement?
- Vertretungen anderer Staaten: Länder A-Z
- Schengen Border Code
- Travelling abroad for refugees (Handbook Germany)

- Visa regulations

What countries are Schengen states?

Germany, Austria, Belgium, Bulgaria, Croatia, the Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Italy, Latvia, Liechtenstein, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden and Switzerland have all acceded to the Schengen Agreement and are thus Schengen states.

The Schengen area thus includes all EU member states except Ireland ; at present the EU members Bulgaria, Cyprus and Romania only apply some of the Schengen provisions. Until these three countries apply what is known as the Schengen acquis in full, as is their aim, passport controls will remain in place at internal borders. In addition to the EU countries already mentioned, Iceland, Norway, Switzerland and Liechtenstein are also Schengen states.

Holders of Schengen visas (text on the visa reads “valid for Schengen states” in the language of the issuing country) may spend up to 90 days in a given 180 days period in the Schengen area, provided their visa is valid at the time. The same applies to holders of most national residence permits and national category D visas issued by individual Schengen states for long-term visits of more than three months. A separate visa may well be needed for travel to other EU states which are not Schengen states.

- The Schengen Agreement
  - Visa regulations

Where do I have to apply for my visa? And who is responsible for the decision?

Visas have to be applied for prior to entry at the German mission abroad covering the place of residence of the applicant.

Please find more information on the webpage of the competent German mission.

The decision on granting a visitor/business visa lies with the competent German mission abroad. The mission also decides on granting visas for longer stays and/or to take up work or studies. These, however, can in most cases only be issued with the approval of the aliens authority concerned.

German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

- Visa regulations

How long does my passport have to be valid if I want to apply for a visa for a trip to Germany?

On the planned date of departure from Germany, your passport has to be valid at least for another three months and it has to be issued within the last 10 years. It should also contain at least two empty pages where the visa can be inserted.

I want to travel to Germany/the Schengen area several times in the next few months. Can I apply for a visa with longer validity?

The mission abroad decides what type of visa to issue (period of validity, number of days covered) on the basis of the documents submitted. If necessary, it may issue a visa that entitles the holder to enter the Schengen area on multiple occasions within the given period of validity. Such annual or multi-annual visas, which are valid for one or more years, are as a rule only issued to persons who have already been to Germany or other Schengen states several times in the past and whom the mission abroad considers to be particularly trustworthy (e.g. because of their position in the host country). Please note that regardless of the length of validity, visas only entitle the holder to a maximum stay of 90 days in any period of 180 days.

- Visa regulations

I am in Germany on a tourist/visitor/business visa. For important reasons, I want to stay in Germany past the expiry date of my visa.

Can I have my visa extended in Germany?

It is only possible to extend the validity of visas in certain exceptional cases. This can only be done by the foreigners authority in Germany covering the place of residence of the visa holder. This is the only authority that can decide on an extension of a visa during a visit to Germany. Neither the Federal Foreign Office nor its missions abroad can do so.

- Visa regulations

What is the procedure for applying for a tourist/visitor/business visa? Can we apply for the visa in Germany?

The visa always has to be applied for by the person who intends to travel to Germany. Details on the documents to be presented at the time of application are often available on the webpage of the competent German mission or directly from the mission itself.

For private visits, an invitation is usually required to confirm the purpose of the journey. In case the visitor is not able to fully cover the expenses associated with the trip a formal pledge to cover all costs (declaration of commitment) has to be presented with the visa application. In this case the host can sign the relevant form (“Verpflichtungserklärung”) at his/her residency's local authorities (usually Ordnungsamt or Ausländerbehörde).

German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

- Visa regulations

For my visa application I need an invitation from a relative/acquaintance living in Germany. What form does such an invitation have to take?

In the first place, an invitation proves the purpose of the intended journey. Therefore, no special formalities are required. If, however, the host intends to cover the expenses associated with the trip, a formal pledge to cover all costs (declaration of commitment) has to be presented with the visa application. In this case the host can sign the relevant form (“Verpflichtungserklaerung”) at his/her residency's local authorities (usually Ordnungsamt or Auslaenderbehoerde).

- Visa regulations

I am not a German national and want to marry my German partner in Germany. What do we have to do to get an entry visa?

First of all find out from the competent registry office in Germany what documents you and your German spouse have to present in order to marry in Germany.

As soon as the registry office confirms your documents are complete, you can apply for a visa to marry in Germany.

Once you are married the final residence and work permit will be issued by the foreigners authority in Germany.

Details on the documents to be presented with your visa application are often available on the webpage of the competent German mission abroad or directly from the mission itself.

- Does my foreign spouse have to provide proof of German language skills when applying for a visa (i.e. before arriving in Germany?)

  - Visa regulations

I am not an EU national and want to live in Germany with my German spouse. What do we have to do?

First of all you have to apply for a visa for family reunification (subsequent immigration of spouses) from the competent German mission abroad.

Documents required include an authenticated marriage certificate as well as the German passport of the German spouse.

The German mission will forward the visa application to the foreigners authority in the place where you want to live in Germany for an opinion.

The German mission abroad can only issue a visa for entry once the foreigners authority has given its approval. The final residence permit will be issued by the foreigners authority in Germany once you are there.

Details on the documents to be presented with your visa application are often available on the webpage of the competent German mission abroad or directly from the mission itself.

- Does my foreign spouse have to provide proof of German language skills when applying for a visa (i.e. before arriving in Germany?)
  - Visa regulations

I am a German citizen and want to move to another EU country with my spouse (who is not an EU citizen). Does my partner require a visa?

National residence permits issued by the Federal Republic of Germany entitle the bearer to travel to the other Schengen countries of the EU without a visa. If you intend to move to an EU country that does not belong to the Schengen area, it is possible that your spouse may not require a visa if he or she holds a national residence permit.

If your spouse does not hold a national residence permit, an entry visa is generally required if he or she is from a country subject to a visa regime. In this case, however, a facilitated visa procedure applies.

A visa is not required if your spouse has been issued with a “Residence card of a family member of a Union citizen” pursuant to Art. 10 (1) of Directive 2004/38/EC. If you and your spouse intend to move from one EU country, of which you are not a national, to another EU country, you should first establish the applicable regulations with regard to visas.

If you have any other questions, please contact the responsible mission abroad for the EU country in question directly and visit their website for further information.

- Does my foreign spouse have to provide proof of German language skills when applying for a visa (i.e. before arriving in Germany?)
  - Visa regulations

I am not a German national but am living and working in Germany with a valid residence permit. Can my spouse ....

...who is also not a German national live and work with me in Germany?

If you want to live in Germany with your spouse you have to submit an application for family reunification to the competent German mission abroad. Details on the documents to be presented with your visa application are often available on the webpage of the competent German mission abroad or directly from the mission itself.

- German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

EU citizens as well as citizens of Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland citizens have the right to live and work in Germany. After arrival, they just need to register with the appropriate office of the town hall (mostly called “Einwohnermeldeamt” or “Bürgeramt”) of their residence in Germany.

- Studying and working in Germany
- Catalogue

Does my foreign spouse have to provide proof of German language skills when applying for a visa (i.e. before arriving in Germany?)

Yes. Under the amended Immigration Act which entered into force on 28 August 2007, foreign spouses have to prove they have at least a basic knowledge of German. For detailed information on this, please click on the link below to the website of the Federal Office for Migration and Refugees. You can also request further information directly from the German diplomatic missions in the respective country.

- Federal Office for Migration and Refugees

Do I need a visa if I want to study/work in Germany?

As a general rule, all foreigners staying in Germany for more than 90 days wanting to work or study in Germany need a visa **before** entering Germany.
For more information:

- What is the procedure for applying for a work visa?
- What is the procedure for applying for a student visa?

Nationals of Australia, Canada, Great Britain, Israel, Japan, New Zealand, South Korea and the United States may apply for the necessary permit after arrival in Germany. The same applies for nationals of Andorra, Brazil, El Salvador, Honduras, Monaco and San Marino who do not intend to take up employment.

EU citizens as well as citizens of Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland citizens have the right to live and work in Germany. After arrival, they just need to register with the appropriate office of the town hall (mostly called “Einwohnermeldeamt” or “Bürgeramt”) of their residence in Germany.

- Visa regulations

What is the procedure for applying for a student visa?

If you plan to study in Germany, you have to submit an application for a student visa to the respective German mission abroad before travelling. Citizens of the EU are exempted from this duty, as well as - under certain conditions according to the EU-mobility program - foreigners who already hold a temporary residence permit as a student issued by another EU-country, due to the EU-mobility program, please see the Implementation Status of the REST-Directive of the Federal Office for Migration and Refugees.

Documents have to be presented proving inter alia that the applicant has been accepted for studies by the university. The German mission abroad will then forward the visa application for an opinion to the foreigners authority in the town housing the University.

The German mission abroad can only issue the visa for entry once the foreigners authority has given its approval.

Details on the documents to be presented with your visa application are often available on the website of the competent German mission abroad or directly from the mission itself. the application form for a visa can be downloaded here.

German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

- Visa regulations

When applying for a student visa, how can I prove that my financing is secure?

Financing can be proved by presenting the income and financial circumstances of parents, by a declaration of commitment in line with Article 66-68 Aufenthaltsgesetz (German Foreigners Act) made by a person with sufficient assets or income, by paying a security into a blocked account in Germany, or by depositing an annually renewable bank guarantee at a bank in Germany.

Proof of sufficient funds is also taken as satisfied if the stay is being financed by a scholarship from public funds or a scholarship from an organization recognized in Germany or a scholarship financed by public funds in the country of origin, if the Federal Foreign Office, the German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD) or another German organization granting scholarships has been responsible for providing the link to a German higher education institution.

- German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD)
- I want to study in Germany. Where can I apply for a scholarship?

- Catalogue

How long does it take to issue my student visa? Can you speed up the process?

Visa applications of students need amongst other things the approval of the competent German alien´s authority. Therefore the processing time for student visas may take several weeks, in individual cases even months. Applicants for student visas are encouraged to read all the relevant information on the respective German mission´s website carefully before their appointment and hand in only complete paperwork. This is the best way to assure a speedy process.

As soon as there is a development in the processing, the applicant will be contacted.

Kindly be advised that the help desk of the German Foreign Office is not able to speed up the process or check the status of the application.

- Visa regulations

What is the procedure for applying for a work visa?

As a general rule non-EU nationals need a residence title (visa or residence permit) to take up employment in Germany. By law the residence title has to give information whether and to which extent access to the labour market is granted. This information replaces the former work permit. If you intend to commence work in Germany you have to apply for a visa with the competent German mission abroad *before* entering Germany. (Only nationals of Australia, Canada, Israel, Japan, New Zealand, South Korea and the United States may apply for the necessary residence title *after* arrival in Germany.)

Details as to which documents have to be presented with your visa application are available on the webpage of the competent German mission abroad or directly from the mission itself.

German missions abroad: Countries A to Z

- Visa regulations

Can I take on holiday jobs in Germany?

Germany has concluded bilateral agreements on working holiday stays with Australia, New Zealand, Japan, the Republic of Korea, Taiwan, Israel, Chile, and the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region.

- Visa regulations